

Blueprint for a better UTT

With a few tweaks here and some tinkering there, the UTT could, in the foreseeable future, give global leagues like the Chinese Super League, Bundesliga and French Pro A **a run for their money.**

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ultimate

/ˈʌltɪmət/
(adjective)

being the best or most extreme example of its kind

It has been seven years since the Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) saw the light of day. Since its inception, the franchise-based league, conducted under the auspices of the Table Tennis Federation of India (TTFI), has gone from strength to strength. With five editions now having rolled by — COVID-19 resulted in a downtime between 2020 and 2022 — it would be fair to give the tournament a once-over and find out to what extent it has lived up to its moniker.

Keeping up the practice from 2019, the UTT, in its entirety, was held at a single venue in 2024. In the first two editions, the UTT caravan had pit stops in three cities, which required players to live out of a suitcase for more than two weeks. Despite noble efforts to popularise table tennis, the sport's niche audience and player fatigue proved challenging. These hurdles led to a shift in the venue, with the action moving to Chennai this year, following successful seasons in Delhi (2019) and Pune (2023).

Promotion blues

With two of the biggest Indian stars, Achanta Sharath Kamal and Sathiyam Gnanasekaran, hailing from Chennai, it was safe to presume that the city would welcome some of India's best paddlers with open arms.

However, empty seats stuck out like sore thumbs on most matchdays, even though only 2,000 of the 8,000



fixed seats in the Jawaharlal Nehru Indoor Stadium (JNIS) were made available for booking. A careful consideration reveals why.

The advertisement campaign left much to be desired. Enveloping state-run buses in bright red UTT vinyl with caricatures of the biggest stars like Manika Batra and Sharath was a marketing genius. Although the move ensured the message got carried around the city on wheels, there were gaps to fill. For starters, the same ad wasn't propagated in the local language. There was a dearth of banners on the streets, even within a two-mile radius of the stadium hosting the event.

Tickets for the general stand were priced as low as Rs 49 — a masala dosa costs more in the metro city — but the tile to promote the same on the ticket-booking platform didn't



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